

KASHI SHINING

1. The revamped Godowlia Chowk

2. Classes at the Machhodari Smart School in the city

3. The Varanasi Trade Facilitation Centre





al Raj Sharma, the commissioner of the Varanasi division. Appointed the district magistrate of Varanasi in November 2019, Sharma was felicitated by PM Modi for topping the Pradhan Mantri Swanidhi Yojana (micro credit and digitisation scheme) in 2021. On July 29 last year, the state government transferred Sharma to Prayagraj, but the order was rescinded within 24 hours after the PMO intervened.

Sharma has been entrusted with the responsibility of completing all the projects under way before the 2024 Lok Sabha election. "The prime minister has introduced a unique development model for temple towns through Varanasi. Develop a religious/ cultural city in a way that it changes the economy of the region and the lives of all the people there," he says.

The results are already beginning to show. According to the Varanasi tourism department, 71.1 million domestic and 83,741 foreign tourists visited the temple town in 2022, which is 15 times the number compared to 2014. Gokul Sharma of the Banaras Hotel Association says, "Kashi Vishwanath Dham has proved to be a jackpot for the tourism industry. Due to the good connectivity with other cities, we get at least 100,000 tourists every day."

As a result, tourism-dependent businesses in Kashi have seen a huge boom. Santosh Kumar, a member of the Varanasi Tourism Guild, says, "Ten years ago, the Taj